

The Social Radars

S5: Jared Friedman, Partner, Y Combinator; Co-founder, Scribd **Released December 30, 2025**

Jessica: [\(00:00:00\)](#) Carolynn, today, we have a very special Social Radars episode because not only is it with a very special person, but we're in person today

Carolynn: [\(00:00:10\)](#) I know. I love it.

Jessica: [\(00:00:10\)](#) In San Francisco. So I'm super tickled. Yes. So today, we have Jared Friedman with us. Hi, Jared.

Carolynn: [\(00:00:19\)](#) Hey, Jared.

Jared: [\(00:00:20\)](#) Hey, guys. Thanks so much for having me on, my favorite podcast.

Jessica: [\(00:00:23\)](#) Oh, listen to him. So Jared was the founder of Scribd, which was in our summer o six batch. He's now has been for a while a Y Combinator partner. Yep. So we've known Jared for forever.

Carolynn: [\(00:00:40\)](#) Well, was gonna say, how old were you when you did YC?

Jared: [\(00:00:42\)](#) I was 20.

Carolynn: [\(00:00:42\)](#) Okay. That's what I thought. I was gonna guess 19, but 20. Yeah.

Jessica: [\(00:00:46\)](#) Hang on. I'm already now shocked, and I've learned something new in five seconds from Jared. You dropped out of Harvard.

Jared: [\(00:00:55\)](#) I did. Yeah. After my junior year.

Carolynn: [\(00:00:57\)](#) Oh, junior year. Okay. Okay.

Jessica: [\(00:00:58\)](#) We're going back. Let's just let's just roll right back. You were a sophomore at Harvard studying what?

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Jared: Computer science.
[\(00:01:05\)](#)

Jessica: Okay. Were you in the undergraduate computer science group that we used to partner with to do start our very first startup school?
[\(00:01:06\)](#)

Jared: I wasn't a member of that club exactly, but I definitely went to the event.
[\(00:01:14\)](#)

Jessica: Oh, you went to startup school?
[\(00:01:18\)](#)

Jared: Yeah. Absolutely. The very first one.
[\(00:01:20\)](#)

Jessica: And how did you first, like, become aware of Y Combinator?
[\(00:01:21\)](#)

Jared: The story really goes back to ninth grade in high school because that is when I read Paul Graham's book on Lisp.
[\(00:01:24\)](#)

Carolynn: Oh my god. You read on Lisp?
[\(00:01:32\)](#)

Jessica: Yeah. I think you and Steve Hoffman.
[\(00:01:34\)](#)

Jared: That's how I learned Lisp. I mean Funny. It's like, if you wanted to read if you wanted to learn Lisp, that was the book that you got. So I got his book.
[\(00:01:36\)](#)

Carolynn: And you're living in man like, grew you up in Manhattan.
[\(00:01:43\)](#)

Jessica: Right? Yeah. Okay. Downtown Manhattan.
[\(00:01:45\)](#)

Jared: Mhmm. To parents who were lawyers.
[\(00:01:47\)](#)

Carolynn: Right. Right. I knew that. That's
[\(00:01:50\)](#)

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Jared: You must They were both lawyers just like John and Carolynn. They actually were like,
[\(00:01:52\)](#) John and Carolynn remind me a lot of my parents

Jessica: Because they were Did they work together?
[\(00:01:59\)](#)

Jared: Cyclor. They did. Yes. Oh, so awesome.
[\(00:02:00\)](#)

Jessica: This story is already just keeps getting better and better. So you're in ninth grade. And
[\(00:02:04\)](#) were you a list packer and you read Paul's book, or you read Paul's book and became a list packer?

Jared: I don't know if I would ever call myself a list packer. That's like a that's like a major, you
[\(00:02:15\)](#) know, like, status symbol in the programming world. But I read Paul's book, and I learned how to program with Lisp. Okay. And then at some point, I started reading his essays.

And I don't remember, unfortunately, how I got from the book to the essays. Maybe I was just curious about who this Paul Graham person was, and I, like, googled for his name, and I found his website, or maybe one of his essays was on slash dot or something. That's a little bit lost of time. But at some point, I began reading his essays, and, you know, I had really enjoyed his book. I really enjoyed his essays.

And so when you announced the summer founders program, I mean, I knew right away because I was on paulgraham.com all the time.

Jessica: Okay. You are one of our earliest users. Yeah. Like because people always say, well, how
[\(00:02:59\)](#) did people even know about Y Combinator? I said, had, like, a bit of a following with young programmers.

That's And

Jared: That's who we right here.
[\(00:03:12\)](#)

Carolynn: The fanboys, the original fanboys.
[\(00:03:13\)](#)

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Jared: Yep. So
[\(00:03:15\)](#)

Jessica: Do were you aware when we launched it for the very first one in o five? Did you apply?
[\(00:03:16\)](#)

Jared: I didn't because I wasn't working on anything at the time. I didn't have a cofounder. I
[\(00:03:22\)](#) didn't have an idea. I had an internship that summer. K.

And but I, like, I definitely planted a seed in my mind that, like, this was the thing that I
wanted to do someday.

Jessica: Okay. So then what?
[\(00:03:38\)](#)

Jared: So then I met my cofounder, who is this guy named Trip. And the way that I met Trip is
[\(00:03:40\)](#) this really goofy story.

Carolynn: Tell it.
[\(00:03:47\)](#)

Jared: Trip, had an idea for a startup, but he was nontechnical, and he needed a technical
[\(00:03:49\)](#) cofounder. So what he did was he emailed the CS undergraduate, like, email list. There
was at the time, one email so you can email all the CS undergraduates. There weren't
that many CS undergraduates back in 2005. It wasn't a very popular major at Harvard.

And he emailed them being like, I have this billion dollar idea, and I'm looking for a
tactical cofounder. Email me if you wanna be my tactical cofounder. And so I emailed
him back.

Jessica: And you'd never met him?
[\(00:04:21\)](#)

Jared: I'd never met him.
[\(00:04:23\)](#)

Jessica: Was he your age?
[\(00:04:24\)](#)

Jared: He was he was one year older.
[\(00:04:24\)](#)

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Jessica: One
[\(00:04:26\)](#)

Jared: Year older. Graduated, but I was still a year away from graduating. That's why I dropped out.
[\(00:04:26\)](#)

Carolynn: What was his major, by the way?
[\(00:04:31\)](#)

Jared: Biophysics, which I think is a thing he's not used one day in his
[\(00:04:32\)](#)

Jessica: Life. Yeah. Trip, of course, we know Carolynn is from grew up in Palo Alto.
[\(00:04:36\)](#)

Carolynn: Oh, I didn't. I don't think I did know that.
[\(00:04:40\)](#)

Jared: On the Stanford campus because his dad was a Stanford professor.
[\(00:04:41\)](#)

Carolynn: Oh, okay. Okay. Okay.
[\(00:04:44\)](#)

Jessica: He was? I am learning so much. I'm already so psyched.
[\(00:04:45\)](#)

Carolynn: We're, like, three minutes in.
[\(00:04:49\)](#)

Jessica: What was he a professor of?
[\(00:04:50\)](#)

Carolynn: Biophysics.
[\(00:04:53\)](#)

Jared: Medicine and an entrepreneur. Tripp's dad actually started two companies. One of them he took public. It's a really big deal. If you if hopefully, you don't ever need his thing, but, like, he built a giant radiotherapy machine that treats people for cancer.
[\(00:04:55\)](#)

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It's like a it's a it's a good cool thing.

Carolynn: Yeah. I think I did know this. I think I had heard that story about Tripp's dad.
[\(00:05:10\)](#)

Jessica: Oh, wow. Yeah. Yeah. Amazing. Yeah.
[\(00:05:14\)](#)

So Tripp grew up.

Jared: He was steeped in this, like, Silicon Valley Yeah. Entrepreneurial culture, always wanted to be an entrepreneur. This was just, like, his path in life.
[\(00:05:17\)](#)

Jessica: Okay. So he's like, I need a programmer, reached out on that very convenient list, and you said, hey. I'm interested in what? Did you, like, meet up for coffee at Harvard Square or something? Or
[\(00:05:23\)](#)

Jared: And we started talking. We realized we kinda, like, hit it off. Yeah. And so we decided to start working together.
[\(00:05:34\)](#)

Jessica: On what ideas?
[\(00:05:41\)](#)

Carolynn: Is ideas compelling?
[\(00:05:42\)](#)

Jared: Enough. Okay. I mean, I think I had been inspired a bit because of the summer founders program. Also, we had both been inspired by Facebook. So, like, Facebook, even though we never worked there, is, like, actually kind of a core part of the story because we I lived literally across the hall from Zuck at Harvard.
[\(00:05:46\)](#)

Jessica: And so Oh my god. This is just getting better and better. You lived on the same hall as Zuckerberg.
[\(00:06:04\)](#)

Jared: I remember watching him walk to the showers.
[\(00:06:11\)](#)

Carolynn: With a little caddy.
[\(00:06:15\)](#)

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Jared: Oh, yeah.
[\(00:06:16\)](#)

Carolynn: Everyone has caddy in shower shoes. That's that's how you do it.
[\(00:06:17\)](#)

Jessica: Was he your age
[\(00:06:21\)](#)

Carolynn: Or a
[\(00:06:22\)](#)

Jared: Year old? He was one year older. He was trips age.
[\(00:06:23\)](#)

Jessica: Okay. Trips age. So what was it like when Zuck was? Tell us about that.
[\(00:06:24\)](#)

Jared: So we had watched Zuck start Facebook. It had taken over at the Harvard campus. Yeah. And then he had left Harvard and moved to Palo Alto to the famous house to start Facebook Right. Which is still, like, basically, like, a seed funded company at the time.

I mean, it wasn't a big deal yet. Right. But even so, we were like, woah. That was pretty cool. What this guy did, maybe we could do that too.

And then Paul, you know, he gave this talk about how to start startups. He wrote the essay.

Jessica: Did you go to that talk?
[\(00:06:57\)](#)

Jared: I did go to the talk. The original talk that was, like, the basis of all of, like, the this whole thing. Yeah. I was

Jessica: Carolynn, the basis of Y Combinator grew it grew out of this talk that Paul gave at Harvard, how to start a startup
[\(00:07:03\)](#)

Jared: Yeah.
[\(00:07:12\)](#)

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Jessica: Which is one of his became an essay.
[\(00:07:12\)](#)

Carolynn: Yeah.
[\(00:07:14\)](#)

Jessica: Yeah. And this is the talk that, Steve Hoffman and Alexis Ohanian came up from University of Virginia Right.

Carolynn: I remember that story.
[\(00:07:21\)](#)

Jessica: And why we funded Reddit. So you were in the audience Yeah. At that talk. So was I. We could have been sitting next to each other.

Jared: We could have been. Yeah.
[\(00:07:30\)](#)

Jessica: What do you think? What did you make of that talk?
[\(00:07:32\)](#)

Jared: Here's what I made of it. No one had ever made the argument to me clearly about why starting a startup could be a smart life choice for someone like me. Everyone had always told me the opposite. They'd always told me, startups are so risky. You should get a job.

Like, you know, you know I don't know. The like, every everyone in my life had always been discouraging about the idea of starting a company. And Paul was the first person who actually knew what he was talking about, who I respected, who stood up and made a very logical argument for why if you were a smart, ambitious undergrad, taking a couple years after college to, like, try your hand in starting a startup would be a smart choice. Like Yeah. If it worked, you get super rich.

If it didn't work, it's no big deal.

Carolynn: Right. You go on with your life.
[\(00:08:22\)](#)

Jessica: Get a job.
[\(00:08:24\)](#)

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Carolynn: Yeah. Yeah.
[\(00:08:24\)](#)

Jessica: Wow. So you left kind of inspired.
[\(00:08:25\)](#)

Jared: Definitely.
[\(00:08:28\)](#)

Jessica: So you think maybe doing startups for me, you're you team up with trip, and he has this billion dollar idea, which is what? Did we hear what it was?

Jared: The idea was basically the idea for Uber, which was, in fact, a billion dollar idea, as we know.

Carolynn: Oh, wow.
[\(00:08:46\)](#)

Jessica: Yeah. Although before smartphones.
[\(00:08:48\)](#)

Jared: That was the problem. That was the problem. So all through the school year, we work on it, because and I meet at the beginning of the school year, so, like, September 2005. And so all through the school year, I'm coding this thing. I'm building the thing.

And when the summer is getting close, we're we're starting to think basically, like, it's going well. Our relationship is going well. Enjoying working on this project, and we're starting to think about, like, actually, like, doing it full time. I'd have to drop out of school. It's a big deal.

But, like, I've been pretty inspired by these multiple, like, touch points in my life, and so I'm, like, pretty gung ho to actually do it. And so, of course, we applied to Y Combinator.

Jessica: Yeah. Okay.
[\(00:09:29\)](#)

Jared: Although, incidentally, I was the one who wanted to apply to Y Combinator.
[\(00:09:31\)](#)

Jessica: Really? The
[\(00:09:36\)](#)

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Jared: Trip was not easily convinced.
[\(00:09:37\)](#)

Jessica: Why? Because we took, like, 7% of the stock?
[\(00:09:39\)](#)

Jared: It wasn't so much that. I think it was the trip you know, he'd grown up in Silicon Valley, like, steeped in this culture.
[\(00:09:45\)](#)

Jessica: Yeah. Yeah. And he had connections.
[\(00:09:51\)](#)

Jared: He had connections.
[\(00:09:53\)](#)

Carolynn: I was just thinking
[\(00:09:54\)](#)

Jared: Dad, you know, had started a public company, and he was just kinda like, I don't know. He you know, unlike me, he hadn't read Paul Graham's book. He hadn't been to that talk. He hadn't read Paul Graham's essays. Like, Paul Graham was a stranger to him.
[\(00:09:54\)](#)

Yeah. And Y Combinator didn't have a track record yet. It wasn't famous at all.

Carolynn: Not at all.
[\(00:10:13\)](#)

Jared: And so he was kinda like, I don't get why my cofounder wants to do this goofy program called Y Combinator. Like, you know, he would he would say, like, Steve Jobs didn't need a program to start Apple.
[\(00:10:14\)](#)

Jessica: I can imagine this. Yes. Yeah.
[\(00:10:26\)](#)

Carolynn: I can too.
[\(00:10:28\)](#)

Jessica: Did you say, let's just interview and see what happens?
[\(00:10:29\)](#)

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Jared: Something like that.
[\(00:10:31\)](#)

Jessica: Yeah. Since it was the summer at the time was in Cambridge, we must have conducted the interviews in Mountain View

Jared: Mountain View.
[\(00:10:40\)](#)

Jessica: Yes. California.
[\(00:10:40\)](#)

Jared: And so I have here the first email that I ever got from you, Jessica. It says, dear Jared, we are really excited to meet you next weekend and discuss your proposal. We have assigned each group a twenty minute time slot and have scheduled you for Sunday, March 5 at 01:45PM. Wow.

Carolynn: That's nice that you saved that. Twenty minutes, though.
[\(00:10:58\)](#)

Jared: Twenty minutes.
[\(00:11:00\)](#)

Jessica: We had long interviews back then. We hadn't quite, gotten to be peak efficient at Y Combinator yet. Yeah.

Carolynn: Make sense.
[\(00:11:08\)](#)

Jessica: I love that I called it a proposal.
[\(00:11:09\)](#)

Jared: Yeah.
[\(00:11:11\)](#)

Jessica: That's sort that's sort of interesting.
[\(00:11:11\)](#)

Jared: And it wasn't even called Y Combinator back then. It was it was still called the Summer Founders Program.

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Jessica: Oh god, Jared. This is embarrassing. You know more than I do.
[\(00:11:18\)](#)

Jared: Yeah. Yeah.
[\(00:11:21\)](#)

Jessica: It was still called the Summer Founders Program.
[\(00:11:22\)](#)

Jared: It was like the Summer Founders Program, like, created by Y Combinator.
[\(00:11:25\)](#)

Jessica: So we were named Y Combinator, but we still called it the Winter Founders Program and the Summer Founders Program.
[\(00:11:28\)](#)

Carolynn: Okay.
[\(00:11:35\)](#)

Jessica: And winter was in Mountain View. Summer was in Cambridge, Massachusetts. Okay. So we interview tell I don't remember the interview. It was so long ago.
[\(00:11:35\)](#)

Do you have any memories of it?

Jared: Well, it was my first time ever in California. I went on real East Coaster. So I didn't even know what Mountain View was. I had to Google, like, what is Mountain View?
[\(00:11:46\)](#)

Carolynn: Did you learn at the time that Google was a Mountain View?
[\(00:11:57\)](#)

Jared: I did. And I was like, oh, okay. I guess that's a legit place to be.
[\(00:11:59\)](#)

Jessica: You'd never been to California? Okay. You must have been struck by it when you came for the weekend.
[\(00:12:02\)](#)

Jared: Yeah. I think like many people who go to Silicon Valley for the first time, I was probably struck by, like, how little there was.
[\(00:12:10\)](#)

Carolynn: How mundane
[\(00:12:16\)](#)

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Jared: It is. Exactly. What I was struck by was the Y Combinator office because at the time, you guys were still sharing an office with AnyBot. In fact, was really the AnyBot's office, and, like, YC was, like, one Squad. One, like
[\(00:12:17\)](#)

Jessica: We had a room.
[\(00:12:30\)](#)

Jared: Piece of it. Yeah. Yeah. And the AnyBot's office was so cool. I had, like, this was, like, exactly the thing that I dreamed of seeing when I went to Silicon Valley.
[\(00:12:31\)](#)

It's, like, a crazy inventor dude with, like, a big white beard building bipedal robots.

Carolynn: Terrifying robots.
[\(00:12:45\)](#)

Jessica: Yes. We had Trevor on the show, and we've talked a lot about in the early days when Y Combinator really didn't have any cache or brand of any sort. An interesting draw was all of his robot stuff. People were psyched to see it.
[\(00:12:46\)](#)

Jared: Yeah. Yeah. So I, yeah, I saw the Antibots today, and I was like, I'm sold. This is amazing. I'm I'm home.
[\(00:12:59\)](#)

Exactly.

Jessica: You remember the actual interview, and did you did we discuss the basically an Uber idea?
[\(00:13:08\)](#)

Jared: We did. And do you know what happened after the interview, Jessica? Do you remember?
[\(00:13:14\)](#)

Jessica: Did Paul say we'll fund you, but not with that idea?
[\(00:13:19\)](#)

Jared: No. Why? He rejected us.
[\(00:13:21\)](#)

Carolynn: Woah. Woah. Just to clarify, was just the two of you at the time. Right?
[\(00:13:24\)](#)

Jared: Well, so there was a third cofounder.
[\(00:13:27\)](#)

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Carolynn:
[\(00:13:30\)](#)

Okay.

Jared:
[\(00:13:31\)](#)

We'll get to that.

Carolynn:
[\(00:13:31\)](#)

Okay. Okay. Put a pin in it.

Jared:
[\(00:13:33\)](#)

Later. Yeah. But, yeah, Paul rejected us. He was just like, this idea won't work.

Jessica:
[\(00:13:38\)](#)

Which he was probably

Jared:
[\(00:13:39\)](#)

Right now. He was totally right. He was totally right. Because this was 2006. The iPhone wasn't invented for a whole other year.

Uh-huh. Uber was started in 2009. You could have never started Uber in 2006. It would have never worked.

Jessica:
[\(00:13:54\)](#)

No. Right. So we rightly rejected you, but I do not remember this. So how did we get you back in?

Jared:
[\(00:14:01\)](#)

So I hope I don't cause an unexpected side effects by saying this, but what happened was Tripp and I argued with Paul over email. We just, like, kept arguing with his rejections.

Carolynn:
[\(00:14:14\)](#)

Oh, wow. That is

Jared:
[\(00:14:16\)](#)

And I pulled up this email thread. It's, like, 16 emails long of us, like, arguing with Paul.

Jessica:
[\(00:14:23\)](#)

Oh my gosh. Usually, it doesn't have the, effect, at least from my experience with him, of, like, getting your way.

Jared:
[\(00:14:31\)](#)

I'm Totally.

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Jessica: So you must have made a good argument.
[\(00:14:32\)](#)

Jared: I don't know if we made a good argument and we convinced him or if he just, like, gave up and decided it would be, like, less effort to accept us than keep arguing with us.
[\(00:14:34\)](#)

Jessica: Really?
[\(00:14:42\)](#)

Jared: So you
[\(00:14:44\)](#)

Carolynn: Have to ask him, by the way, because I would like to know the answer to that.
[\(00:14:44\)](#)

Jared: We'll see if he remembers. Yeah.
[\(00:14:48\)](#)

Jessica: How did he end? Was he like, okay. Fine. You're in?
[\(00:14:49\)](#)

Jared: Basically. Yeah.
[\(00:14:52\)](#)

Jessica: Wow.
[\(00:14:53\)](#)

Jared: And what convinced him was we agreed in this very long email chain to change our idea
[\(00:14:54\)](#)

Jessica: Okay.
[\(00:15:00\)](#)

Jared: To an idea that he was more excited about, which is this idea of Craigslist for colleges.
[\(00:15:00\)](#)

Jessica: Okay. Now I remember because that's what I have in my brain of you guys, and you were called who list?
[\(00:15:05\)](#)

Jared: Who list? The Harvard University list.
[\(00:15:12\)](#)

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Jessica: Oh, starting just like Zuckerberg, Harry.
[\(00:15:15\)](#)

Jared: Just like Zuckerberg.
[\(00:15:17\)](#)

Jessica: I could see how Paul was excited, and we were excited about this.
[\(00:15:19\)](#)

Jared: Because, like, Trip and I, you know, looked a lot like the Facebook founders in terms of our background. We were following a playbook that had just worked the prior year, started Harvard, expand school by school to all the schools. Yeah. We didn't need smartphones for the idea to make sense.
[\(00:15:22\)](#)

Jessica: Yeah. Okay. I almost I'm embarrassed to say, but do we need to explain for the younger listeners what Craigslist is? Like, when we say Craigslist for colleges. So tell us about who it is.
[\(00:15:35\)](#)

Jared: So Craigslist was this really big website at the time. It's still pretty big in SF, but less so in other places, where you could buy and sell stuff on the Internet. It's from, like, the mid nineties, really old website.
[\(00:15:45\)](#)

Jessica: It was in my book, Founders at Work.
[\(00:15:57\)](#)

Jared: Oh, that's right. Newmark. The interview with Craig Newmark. Yeah. He must have been an interesting character to interview.
[\(00:15:58\)](#)

Jessica: Indeed. He was.
[\(00:16:04\)](#)

Jared: You know, he lived two blocks from me in San Francisco for, like, many years. I'd see him, like, walking down the street all the time. Yeah. He lived in Coal
[\(00:16:05\)](#)

Jessica: Valley. Random. So random. Okay. So you're doing, Craigslist for colleges college.
[\(00:16:12\)](#)

Starting at Harvard University.

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Jared:
[\(00:16:21\)](#) And so the idea is, like, if you're at Harvard, maybe you'd, like, finish using a textbook because you just finished the course and you wanna sell the textbook to somebody else. You could just list the textbook on our website. Some other students just starting the course. They need the textbook. They buy the textbook from you.

Jessica:
[\(00:16:35\)](#) Yeah. Or a lamp or piece

Jared:
[\(00:16:37\)](#) Of furniture or

Jessica:
[\(00:16:37\)](#) Any anything. Okay. So what happened? When and, you, at this point, were not definitely had dropped out?

Jared:
[\(00:16:46\)](#) Or So I was finishing my junior year. Yep. And at the time, you know, the summer founders program was, like, somewhat agnostic about whether the participants should go back to college

Jessica:
[\(00:16:54\)](#) Or not. Yes.

Jared:
[\(00:16:56\)](#) And so I hadn't really decided to drop out. I you know, it was really positioned as, a summer founders program, and then we'll see. Yeah. Right? And, well, the next the next part of the story is really where Carolynn enters.

Carolynn:
[\(00:17:10\)](#) Alright. Yeah. Because

Jared:
[\(00:17:13\)](#) My first interaction with Carolynn was that spring. And I don't know if you remember why we needed Carolynn.

Carolynn:
[\(00:17:20\)](#) So I do have a recollection of the three of you sitting in the conference room at Wilson's on scene arguing. No. I'm sorry.

Jared:
[\(00:17:28\)](#) That was a whole year later.

Carolynn:
[\(00:17:29\)](#) Oh, okay. Then I don't remember the first time.

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- Jared:
[\(00:17:31\)](#) Okay. In the spring of two thousand six, the reason that we needed Carolyn is that before the summer founders program even started, we had a cofounder breakup. Oh my gosh. Because there was a long lost third cofounder who nobody remembers Nope. Named Ivo Parashevov, who was my random Harvard friend that I had, like, convinced to join this venture with me and Tripp.
- Carolynn:
[\(00:17:53\)](#) Wait. Why'd you want him to join, though?
- Jared:
[\(00:17:55\)](#) He was really smart. He was really smart. He was a programmer. I knew him really well. He's gone on to be actually quite successful in his own right.
- But he and Tripp never got along, so he didn't fly out to the YC entry. This is before you reimbursed airfare. So our excuse was, like, it's expensive. Like, how about only two of us come? Can And you were like, alright.
- Fine. But during the spring, as, like, after we got into Y Combinator, things started getting real. He was just, like realized that Tripp and I had no idea what we were doing, and he was like, this startup sucks. Ike, I'm out.
- Jessica:
[\(00:18:29\)](#) Had you incorporated yet?
- Jared:
[\(00:18:31\)](#) We had also incorporated. So before we got into Y Combinator, we had incorporated using some shitty online incorporation thing that I found. And so poor Carolyn had to clean up our totally messed up incorporation and deal with the cofounder breakup and the release paperwork and, like, reducing Ubus Equity and all of this junk.
- Carolynn:
[\(00:18:48\)](#) This is kind of sounding familiar now.
- Jared:
[\(00:18:50\)](#) Okay. Got on a call with me from Hawaii where you and Paul were on vacation.
- Jessica:
[\(00:18:55\)](#) By the way,
- Jared:
[\(00:18:56\)](#) To deal with this cofounder breakup mess of these, you know, two 20 year old kids that you just funded.

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Carolynn: Can we just pause for a minute and, like, marble at Jared's memory? Like, the bar for me is low because I have no memory, but, like, you this is amazing.
[\(00:19:02\)](#)

Jessica: Am learning so much.
[\(00:19:11\)](#)

Carolynn: What about yourself?
[\(00:19:13\)](#)

Jessica: Just I hadn't I don't remember any of this. It's amazing, Jared. I'm maybe I'll have Jared joined John Levy in helping me write the Y Combinator book.
[\(00:19:14\)](#)

Carolynn: Well, I think that's a given. You absolutely should have Jared help with that. So Clearly, we're gonna be useless.
[\(00:19:24\)](#)

Jessica: Yes. We're gonna be useless. So you I was in Hawaii. And what did I say? Like
[\(00:19:31\)](#)

Jared: Well, to your credit, you didn't kick us out. I mean, it would have been totally reasonable for you to have been like, well, you know, we funded the three of you when, like, you've already changed your idea, you've lost a cofounder, and you're not even sure you're gonna drop out of college. Why don't you guys just, like, graduate? And, you know, you can always apply to YC in, like, a year. That wouldn't have been a totally reasonable thing for you to do.
[\(00:19:37\)](#)

Jessica: And But you're not our style. Not our style. Once you're in, you're in. Okay. So, gosh, I had forgotten about the third cofounder.
[\(00:19:53\)](#)

Okay. So that worked out then? Okay.

Jared: That's fine.
[\(00:20:05\)](#)

Jessica: Then you come back to Cambridge
[\(00:20:05\)](#)

Jared: Yep.
[\(00:20:07\)](#)

Jessica: For, you know, for we kick off the program. It must have been in, like, the first week of June.
[\(00:20:08\)](#)

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Jared: Yep. And it took place just a few blocks from the apartment that I was living in
[\(00:20:12\)](#) Cambridge.

Jessica: Really? Yeah. Where were you living?
[\(00:20:17\)](#)

Jared: On Garden Street.
[\(00:20:19\)](#)

Jessica: Literally a few blocks.
[\(00:20:21\)](#)

Jared: Literally the same street. Street. The Yes.
[\(00:20:22\)](#)

Carolynn: Wow. This really feels like fate. I mean, everything the stars aligned everywhere you
[\(00:20:26\)](#) look.

Jessica: I love Garden Street.
[\(00:20:32\)](#)

Jared: Yeah. It's a bit it's such a pretty, like, spot in the world. Definitely.
[\(00:20:33\)](#)

Jessica: It really is. Okay. So did we have good speakers? Do you remember that?
[\(00:20:38\)](#)

Jared: Yeah. There is Steven Wolfram. He was really good. There was, what's his name? The
[\(00:20:42\)](#) founder of Android, The guy who created Android who Yes.

Whose company had just been acquired by Google. Android wasn't even released yet.

Jessica: Yes. Rich
[\(00:20:54\)](#)

Jared: Rich Miner.
[\(00:20:55\)](#)

Jessica: Rich Miner.
[\(00:20:56\)](#)

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Jared: Miner. Yep. The guy who is the founder of TripAdvisor who was in your book.
[\(00:20:56\)](#)

Jessica: Yes. Steve Cowfer.
[\(00:21:01\)](#)

Jared: And I don't remember anything about his talk, but I remember one thing, which is he had to leave the dinner early because he was flying to France to ride wild ponies on the beach. Wow. Or wild horses on the beach.

Jessica: Got Jared, you are blowing my mind Yeah. At this point.
[\(00:21:19\)](#)

Jared: So I don't remember any of his advice. Although, I did read the chapter in your book, and that chapter is filled with amazing advice. But I remember the wild horses story because I was like, okay. Well, that's what life looks like after you've exited your startup. Wow.

You're like You just

Carolynn: Go to France and ride ponies.
[\(00:21:36\)](#)

Jessica: But wild. Wild ponies. Are
[\(00:21:38\)](#)

Carolynn: You supposed to ride wild ponies? Oh my
[\(00:21:42\)](#)

Jessica: Goodness. And was this still back in the days where Paul didn't have, like, formal office hours? Would you just say, hey. Can we meet or whatever?

Jared: I remember. There was I got this email from you, Jessica. It says, hi, guys. Can you meet Paul tomorrow at his house at 3PM to brainstorm? How is how office hours work?

Have you, like, start

Jessica: Love how, like, we just did everything. I was, like, Paul's sec personal secretary.
[\(00:22:06\)](#)

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Carolynn: You gotta do what you gotta do when you're starting a biz when you're starting a
[\(00:22:11\)](#) company. Yeah. So everybody, all hands on deck.

Jessica: Oh my gosh. And that was at his house on Avon Street.
[\(00:22:16\)](#)

Jared: About to. Yeah.
[\(00:22:19\)](#)

Carolynn: Oh my gosh. And just to be clear, it's just the two of you at this point.
[\(00:22:20\)](#)

Jared: It was only the two of us at that point. Yeah.
[\(00:22:23\)](#)

Jessica: And it got some traction. Right? Tell us how
[\(00:22:25\)](#)

Jared: No. It didn't, unfortunately, is the problem. Yeah. So, yeah, so we worked on this Graces
[\(00:22:28\)](#) of Ecologist thing all summer. We got to the end of the summer.

We didn't really have any traction. You can't really launch a product for buying and selling stuff the summer. In the summer because there's no college students on campus. Yeah. And so we got to the end of the batch, and we did demo day.

And we basically had no users. Yeah. And so we didn't raise any money. Oh, no. Which wasn't ideal because, you know, YC didn't invest that much money in companies in the day.

So, like, we were kinda, like didn't really have any money.

Jessica: Like, \$12,000.
[\(00:23:02\)](#)

Jared: It was \$12,000.
[\(00:23:03\)](#)

Carolynn: Yeah. Ouch.
[\(00:23:04\)](#)

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Jared:
[\(00:23:04\)](#) Ouch. And so I had to make a decision about whether I wanna get to school or whether I wanna continue working on this. Yeah. And, really I mean, there are a couple of things. One, I was I was having a good time.

Like, I like working with Trip. I love the Y Combinator community. Just the whole vibe of the people who are working on their startups is just so much more fun than school. I didn't really wanna go back to school and do problem sets and, like, solve made up problems for professors. It just seemed like very shallow after, like, doing the real thing.

You know? Right. And then also, like, I kinda wanna see it through. Like, we basically spent all summer building this product. I really wanted to launch it and see if it would work.

Jessica:
[\(00:23:38\)](#) Right.

Jared:
[\(00:23:38\)](#) You know, I was curious. And so I decided to take at least one semester off.

Jessica:
[\(00:23:42\)](#) Okay.

Jared:
[\(00:23:43\)](#) And in September and October, we spent the, you know, the fall semester really trying to get this thing working at Harvard and then at other college campuses. And, unfortunately, by the end of October, we had to admit to ourselves that this idea was just not something people wanted. Like, nobody wanted this website.

Jessica:
[\(00:24:01\)](#) Why didn't they want it?

Jared:
[\(00:24:02\)](#) I know now. And, the reason is it's a timing problem. Craigslist works because people buy and sell things at, like, random times, but college students are all synchronized. Everybody comes back to school in September, and they wanna buy everything in September, and nobody wants to sell anything. And then in May, everybody wants to sell everything, and nobody's buying.

Jessica:
[\(00:24:24\)](#) It's like a lopsided market.

Jared:
[\(00:24:25\)](#) Yes. Exactly.

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Jessica: Yeah. Okay. Interesting.
[\(00:24:26\)](#)

Jared: And that's why to this day, no one has ever started a successful crisis for colleges. Although, I learned randomly that Tom Blomfield started the same exact idea. His first startup was also a crisis for colleges. Really? And we both came to the same conclusion that data cannot work for this, like, structural problem.

Jessica: Okay. So tell us how you morphed into Scribd.
[\(00:24:43\)](#)

Jared: So then we spent a few months in a trough of sorrow Yes. When we were trying to figure out, like, what to do. We went through probably a dozen different ideas, and we launched a lot of them. We would go through these, like, sprints where we'd, like, have a random idea. We'd build a thing.

We'd launch it. We'd be like, oh, that thing sucks. And then we'd it again. During this time, I decided to move out to San Francisco. That was a big, like, turning point in the company because we'd done YC back in Cambridge, of course, and I'm the East Coaster.

The only time I'd ever been to California was for, like, one day for the, like, Y Combinator interview. Yeah. But Trip was, like, from Palo Alto, grew up in Silicon Valley. He kept telling me, like, we gotta be in Silicon Valley. That's the place to be.

That's where all the startups are.

Jessica: Rightly so.
[\(00:25:34\)](#)

Jared: Rightly so, though I was very skeptical because I was just like, I don't know. I've been to Silicon Valley. It's just like a bunch of, like, suburbs. Like, it doesn't seem that great to me. I don't know.

Right. Right.

Jessica: And we have to ask, what did your parents think of all of this?
[\(00:25:45\)](#)

Carolynn: Yes. It's question.
[\(00:25:48\)](#)

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Jared:
[\(00:25:50\)](#) Yeah. The trademark question. They were, like, not exactly excited about it, but they also weren't, like, jumping up and down on me. Like, I was always a very independently minded person, and I think they had a sense that I was, like, very hardworking and ambitious, and I probably wouldn't end up homeless on, like, a street corner somewhere that, like, I'd figure it out. And yeah.

And so they weren't, like, overly alarmed.

Jessica:
[\(00:26:12\)](#)

Jared:
[\(00:26:14\)](#) So Trip eventually convinced me to go out to Silicon Valley, and we end up moving into this building, Crystal Towers.

Jessica:
[\(00:26:22\)](#)

Jared:
[\(00:26:24\)](#) The which is became dubbed the Y Scraper because there were so many Y Combinator companies living in it. Yes. And that was actually a really big, like, decision for us because we were in this building now with, you know, the Reddits were there. Later on, like, the Stripe founders were there. The Dropbox founders were there.

Jessica:
[\(00:26:46\)](#)

Jared:
[\(00:26:47\)](#) Weebly. Yeah. Like, all of these epic companies. Yeah. And, it's basically in the course of, like, being in that community, that early YC community, which was pretty focused on this one particular building at that time Yeah.

That we, like, got the idea for Scribd and also got the energy to keep going.

Jessica:
[\(00:27:08\)](#) I could see how it provided more energy because everyone was working on cool ideas. How did you get the idea for Scribd?

Jared:
[\(00:27:16\)](#) We were, like, brainstorming random x for y ideas. And, like, YouTube is, like, the hottest company at the time because it just got bought by Google for, like, \$2,000,000,000. And so, like, YouTube for x's were, like, really popular, but no one was doing YouTube for documents.

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Jessica: Because it's kinda boring?
[\(00:27:31\)](#)

Jared: Because yeah. Because it seems like a bad idea. You know? It's like intersection that seems like a bad idea is a good idea. Right?
[\(00:27:32\)](#)

Yeah. Yeah. Yeah. So we had the idea for Scribd. We built it over the winter.

We launched it in March 2007, and we were pretty out of gas by then. Like, I think, you know, we sort of been working on stuff for a while and, like, nothing was working. We hadn't raised any money, so we were, like, running on fumes. Oh, boy. And I don't know that we would have kept going much longer, honestly, if it hadn't worked.

Yeah. But it did work, and the launch really took off.

Jessica: Tell us about it. That was the glimmer of hope.
[\(00:28:09\)](#)

Jared: Point. Yeah. And that was the second time when I metCarolynn, because our launch, like, really blew up. It was on it was at the top of Hacker News, which existed at the time. It was at the top of TechCrunch and Slashdot and Digg and Reddit and all of these big sites.
[\(00:28:11\)](#)

It got picked up by, like, actual, like, like, journalists at, like, proper, like, news outlets like The New York Times and either ABC or NBC. It was even on cable news. I remember one day we woke up, and there was one of those old school cable news vans, you know, with the big satellite dish Oh, yeah. On the top, parked outside of the wisecraper

Jessica: No way.
[\(00:28:47\)](#)

Jared: They wanted to film the three guys making YouTube for documents.
[\(00:28:48\)](#)

Carolynn: Oh, wow. That's awesome.
[\(00:28:52\)](#)

Jessica: Oh my gosh.
[\(00:28:55\)](#)

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Jared:
[\(00:28:56\)](#) And so we went from totally, you know, failing, no idea what we were doing, pivoting through random ideas, lost kids, essentially, to being, for a brief moment, one of the hottest companies in Silicon Valley. Yeah. And we went from being totally broke to having multiple term sheets for a series a in, like, a few weeks.

Jessica:
[\(00:29:17\)](#) Alright. Who gave you term sheets, and who did you take?

Jared:
[\(00:29:20\)](#) Yeah. So we got term sheets from Redpoint and CRV and Sequoia. Mhmm. And we ended up going with Redpoint. Mhmm.

And that was when you reintroduced us to Carolyn because you're like, these guys need help with their series a.

Jessica:
[\(00:29:31\)](#) Yeah.

Carolynn:
[\(00:29:32\)](#) Yeah.

Jessica:
[\(00:29:32\)](#) Yeah. I remember Red Point.

Carolynn:
[\(00:29:36\)](#) Jeffrey Yang.

Jared:
[\(00:29:37\)](#) Yep. Jeffrey Yang.

Carolynn:
[\(00:29:37\)](#) Super nice Yeah.

Jessica:
[\(00:29:39\)](#) Okay. So, Carolyn, what do you remember?

Carolynn:
[\(00:29:42\)](#) Well, I alluded to this earlier. But so TCON was a late join, and I believe that you guys came into the Wilson Sonseti Conference Room to talk about how much stock he would get and what his vesting would be. And that's where the fireworks started.

Jessica:
[\(00:29:56\)](#) Oh gosh. Well, expand a little bit on T Con.

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Jared:
[\(00:29:59\)](#) So T Con was another founder in the summer founders program in the summer two thousand six batch. He was a solo founder working on his own company, and his company, you know, like ours, didn't really go anywhere.

Jessica:
[\(00:30:13\)](#) Mhmm.

Jared:
[\(00:30:14\)](#) And after the batch, he was sort of deciding what to do, and he basic he basically just asked Tripp and me if he could join us, and we were like, sure. And so he became the third cofounder.

Jessica:
[\(00:30:26\)](#) Yeah. Was T Con from Palo Alto as well and new Tripp? Okay. Yes. Alright.

Okay. So they're in your office, and that's how

Carolynn:
[\(00:30:34\)](#) You met them. Yeah. So they obviously as a third cofounder, he needed to get some equity. And I think Jared was just sitting there like, I don't care about this. My vibe from you was like, oh my gosh.

Why are we fighting about this? But Trip and are, like, going at it. And that's where I was like, wow. This is this is not great. And these people are very young.

That's what I was thinking.

Jared:
[\(00:30:57\)](#) Very young and extremely immature. I

Carolynn:
[\(00:31:00\)](#) Really hope they figure this out. I don't know what I can do here. This is, like, such an interpersonal thing here. Like, I can say what market standard is, but, you know anyway. So I do remember that vividly.

I don't actually remember anything particular about your series a. I'm sure it was just a standard fundraise.

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- Jared:
[\(00:31:19\)](#) It was pretty standard except there was one wrinkle, which is from the moment that Scribd launched, we were a hotbed of piracy and copyright infringement. And so at the same time, we were fielding off VCs with a stick who were trying to invest in our company. We were also fighting off book publishers and authors who were threatening to sue us. And so we spent a lot of time at the Wilson Sonsini office with Brian Mendonso in particular who is a godsend.
- Carolynn:
[\(00:31:44\)](#) Yes. He's great.
- Jared:
[\(00:31:45\)](#) Yes. Keeping us from getting sued out of existence. If not for Brian Mendoza, I think the company would have died basically as soon as it launched. Wow.
- Jessica:
[\(00:31:53\)](#) How did you how did he help you solve this?
- Jared:
[\(00:31:56\)](#) Well, he had been the lawyer for YouTube.
- Jessica:
[\(00:31:58\)](#) Oh my god.
- Jared:
[\(00:31:59\)](#) He knew everything about this. He was like the world expert at how to build a YouTube and not get sued out of existence.
- Jessica:
[\(00:32:04\)](#) Wow. I did not know that.
- Carolynn:
[\(00:32:07\)](#) So you guys then, so how much did you raise in your series a?
- Jared:
[\(00:32:10\)](#) \$4,000,000, which seemed like a lot of money. That was a lot of money back sounds, then. Like, so quaint. Do you
- Carolynn:
[\(00:32:16\)](#) Remember what the valuation was?
- Jared:
[\(00:32:17\)](#) Riding your horse to school or something.

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Carolynn: Yeah. Really. What, do you remember the valuation?
(00:32:19)

Jared: I think it was '21 post.
(00:32:22)

Jessica: '21 post.
(00:32:24)

Carolynn: So much. A big deal back Totally. Oh my goodness. And then you guys I remember you guys started having regular board meetings, which I showed up to, and we need to talk about that office.
(00:32:25)

Jared: We definitely should talk about the office. It was the same office building as Zotney.
(00:32:37)

Carolynn: Okay.
(00:32:43)

Jessica: Which was, NYC that
(00:32:44)

Jared: In our batch. They were they were, like, the hottest company in summer two thousand. They moved out to Silicon Valley and raised a series a months before we did. And so they were like gods in our eyes. Like, them and Reddit and Looped were the three companies that were, like, really, like, had turned into something.
(00:32:47)

Jessica: Right. And, to refresh people's memory, Adam Smith and Matt. Adam Smith was Drew Houston's, like, little brother in his fraternity at MIT, and that's what spurred Drew to be like, hey. If he can do it, I should be able to do it. And he was a guest at the YC dinner where he asked all the questions, Carolynn.
(00:33:05)

Remember when he talked about that?

Jared: So the office. So, it was there. It was also, in just the next building over from what was the Dropbox office. Actually, Scribd and Dropbox shared a wall.
(00:33:29)

Carolynn: Oh, wow.
(00:33:42)

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Jared: Yeah. For years. But what was your recollection of the office?
[\(00:33:42\)](#)

Carolynn: So it was actually a very cool space. But my recollection is that, you know, we go into this conference room. There'd be, like, a very serious board meeting. Because your guys' board meetings, I recall, they were, like, really pretty good.

Jared: Okay.
[\(00:33:58\)](#)

Jessica: Like, serious I'm
[\(00:33:58\)](#)

Jared: Surprised to hear that since we had no idea what happened in a board meeting.
[\(00:33:59\)](#)

Carolynn: Well, keep in mind, I went to a lot of startup company board meetings. So there's you know? Yours was pretty good. But then afterwards, it's like, hey. Wanna go on our zipline?

Jared: Oh, yeah.
[\(00:34:11\)](#)

Carolynn: So I'm like I mean, like, like, back in the day, you kinda dress up a little bit for board meetings still. And so I'm, like, in this, like, semi professional outfit. I'm, like, hanging from this zipline going, wee, in this office and this big loft space. And you guys had, like, you had, like, go karts.

Jared: We had go karts, and we would race around the office.
[\(00:34:32\)](#)

Jessica: That sounds familiar. I think I remember the go karts.
[\(00:34:34\)](#)

Jared: Yeah. You and Paul came and visited the office Yeah. Not too long after we moved in. Maybe a few months you were in NSF or something else, and you stopped by. And that was a big moment for us that you guys were, like, willing to come to our office.

I, like, vividly remember, like, how big a deal it was.

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Carolynn: Did you guys put all the toys in, or had you rented it, like and the prior tenants had done all that?
[\(00:34:53\)](#)

Jared: No. The toys were definitely ours.
[\(00:34:58\)](#)

Carolynn: Oh, okay. Okay. And when you say ours, like, your idea or Tripp and Tikkahn's idea?
[\(00:34:59\)](#)

Jared: I think it was mostly a Tripp and Tikkahn thing. Okay.
[\(00:35:05\)](#)

Jessica: Did I ride a go kart? That's what I really think you
[\(00:35:07\)](#)

Jared: Rode a go kart.
[\(00:35:09\)](#)

Jessica: That doesn't
[\(00:35:10\)](#)

Jared: Sound like me. Noticed the go karts and was like,
[\(00:35:10\)](#)

Jessica: I hope you're
[\(00:35:16\)](#)

Carolynn: Doing that off hours. So
[\(00:35:16\)](#)

Jessica: Then did you have all this momentum behind Scribd. Yeah. Did it keep the momentum, or what No. Then happened?
[\(00:35:20\)](#)

Jared: So it, you know, it was a roller coaster of a company. Our hope was that it would be the next YouTube. You know, we'd followed a YouTube story they just launched, and then the thing just, like, grew exponentially, and then they got acquired for \$2,000,000,000. And it continued to grow exponentially even after this. Like, insane, insane story.
[\(00:35:28\)](#)

Right? Yeah. And so, like, we thought that we would be on that trajectory, but we were not, unfortunately. Shortly after we raised our series a, our traffic did, like, plummeted. Oh, no.

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And in fact, during our whole series a, Paul was checking in with us to, you know, see how things were going, and he was every email from him was like, close the round faster. Like, your round is going to fall apart. Wow. It probably would've if the investors had just asked for updated numbers during closing, but they didn't do that. They handed it off to their lawyers who just asked about, like, legal things, and they didn't realize that That the business was falling apart.

Carolynn: Minor detail. Minor detail.
[\(00:36:21\)](#)

Jessica: Goodness. Wow.
[\(00:36:23\)](#)

Jared: And the thing that actually and, honestly, like, the company would have died. And the thing that rescued it is we went to a Y Combinator event, some dinner that you guys were hosting with founders. I think it was just, a regular Tuesday night dinner, you guys just invited us because you would invite alumni occasionally just hang out.
[\(00:36:25\)](#)

Jessica: Yes. Totally.
[\(00:36:42\)](#)

Jared: And so we're just hanging out with, like, the new batch of founders, and we struck up a conversation with Paul who was hanging around on that dinner. And in, you know, his, like, quintessential, like, Paul Buchite way, he just, like, offhand dropped this, like, incredibly brilliant idea that totally changed the trajectory of the company.
[\(00:36:43\)](#)

Jessica: Tell us. Typical.
[\(00:37:03\)](#)

Jared: He told us that what we had built was not actually, like, a YouTube like site because it's not entertaining. Like, documents are not entertaining, like videos are. He told us that what we'd actually built was an SEO destination and that the way to make Scribd work was to get lots and lots of search traffic from Google. And he told us how to do that because he'd worked at Google, and so he really understood Google and search traffic in this whole world. And he basically just, like, gave us the playbook for how to do it, and, that that changed everything.
[\(00:37:04\)](#)

Carolynn: How long did it take you to implement Paul's idea?
[\(00:37:32\)](#)

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Jared: Oh, like, that night.
[\(00:37:34\)](#)

Carolynn: Really quickly. Really quickly. PB
[\(00:37:36\)](#)

Jessica: PB to the rescue. Yeah.
[\(00:37:39\)](#)

Carolynn: Amazing. Wow.
[\(00:37:40\)](#)

Jared: So I'll always be grateful to PB for that. And so that worked. So we implemented Paul ideas, and that created a viral growth loop where, like, the core growth loop of Scribd is people upload some documents. Google sends us free traffic of random people who happen to want information in those documents.
[\(00:37:42\)](#)

Carolynn: Right.
[\(00:37:58\)](#)

Jared: Yep. Once in a while, one of those people uploads their own document and adds to the collection. Yeah. And, basically, we got the viral growth factor of that loop to be greater than one, and the thing just, like, took off like a rocket. And just two years after that fateful meeting with Paul, would never have happened if you hadn't invited us to that random batch dinner.
[\(00:37:58\)](#)

Oh my gosh. So it's, like, saved the whole company. Oh my gosh. Scribd is one of the top 100 sites on the web.

Jessica: Amazing.
[\(00:38:25\)](#)

Jared: We had more than a billion people coming to Scribd every year.
[\(00:38:25\)](#)

Carolynn: Wow. Wow. Yeah. What's what's a what's a very, like, canonical use case for Scribd, for just the average person using Scribd?
[\(00:38:29\)](#)

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Jared:
[\(00:38:40\)](#) One of my favorite use cases is sheet music. So I'm an amateur pianist, and I would often look for sheet music on the Internet. And the best place to find it was Scribd because somebody would have, like, transcribed a song Yeah. Uploaded it to Scribd, and you could just search for, you know you know, sheet music for x. And, like, there a Scribd doc would, like, pop up.

Carolynn:
[\(00:38:59\)](#) Pop up. Yeah. But you have to have good SEO to make that happen.

Jared:
[\(00:39:02\)](#) You have to have good SEO. Yeah.

Jessica:
[\(00:39:03\)](#) That's amazing. Play the piano a lot still?

Jared:
[\(00:39:06\)](#) Yeah. From time to time.

Jessica:
[\(00:39:08\)](#) What's your favorite kind of music to play?

Jared:
[\(00:39:10\)](#) Broadway show tunes.

Carolynn:
[\(00:39:11\)](#) Nice. Mhmm.

Jessica:
[\(00:39:12\)](#) Oh, Jared. Oh, we're gonna have to put like, take this offline because I like Broadway show tunes. Love Broadway show tunes. Oh my god.

Carolynn:
[\(00:39:21\)](#) I can actually sing a lot of Broadway shows that I just listened to as a child, so I actually have all the lyrics memorized. Like, I could sing most of Evita. I mean, I can't

Jared:
[\(00:39:29\)](#) Sing it. Come to one of our show tune nights? We do we do show tune nights where I play piano when people sing.

Jessica:
[\(00:39:35\)](#) Oh, we're doing that while I'm in town.

Carolynn:
[\(00:39:38\)](#) Yes. As long as it's a musical, I know the words too.

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Jessica: Yeah. Oh my gosh. Okay. Show tunes night at Jared's house. Okay.
[\(00:39:41\)](#)

Carolynn: I'm in. So this what you just described, that happened in between the a and the b, or had
[\(00:39:45\)](#) did you need the b to make that happen?

Jared: It happened throughout, like, the a to the c, I would say. Yeah. That that that that whole
[\(00:39:52\)](#) process.

Carolynn: And Red Point kept putting money in.
[\(00:40:00\)](#)

Jared: Mhmm. And then CRV, which we turned down in the series a came back, they let her be,
[\(00:40:02\)](#) which I'm very grateful for. Yeah. Those guys were amazing.

Carolynn: Yes.
[\(00:40:09\)](#)

Jared: Bill. Yep. Bill.
[\(00:40:10\)](#)

Jessica: Yeah. Yeah. Yeah.
[\(00:40:12\)](#)

Jared: George Zachary. And it was very close, though, because we raised our series b at the
[\(00:40:13\)](#) worst possible time. So we raised our series a on the back of this, like, launch hype, which all went away. Then Paul saved the company. We had all this traffic.

We get ready, geared up to raise a series b, and we think it's gonna be a piece of cake because, like, our traffic growth is, like, insane. We have, like, you know, millions of people on our site. Like, we think, like, this is gonna be, like, a really hot round. But then shortly before we go out to raise, the financial crisis starts. Oh.

And, basically, all the VCs just, like, close-up top.

Carolynn: This is 2008?
[\(00:40:56\)](#)

Jessica: Yeah. Okay. I just watched the big short last night, by the way. Oh. Oh my gosh.
[\(00:40:57\)](#)

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And it triggered me back to, like, the YC days, and I was trying to explain to my younger son, like, what how Y Combinator was affected.

Carolynn:
[\(00:41:11\)](#)

A part of it.

Jessica:
[\(00:41:12\)](#)

Yeah. Yeah.

Jared:
[\(00:41:12\)](#)

Yeah. A scary time.

Jessica:
[\(00:41:14\)](#)

It really was. Yeah. So what happened?

Jared:
[\(00:41:16\)](#)

Well, we weren't. We had all this traffic, but we weren't making much revenue. We tried to monetize the site, but, basically, just by putting ads on it. So we had ads on the site, but they weren't making us that much money. And we'd hired a pretty big team, and we had a pretty big burn rate because we felt confident that we'd be able to raise this next round because, like, the biz like, the traffic was growing so much.

Yeah. But we didn't really have an easy path to getting, like, default alive. Like, we have to raise money or it was gonna be really bad. And I'm just really grateful that the CRV guys were just, like, unperturbed by the financial crisis. They were like, we'd liked you guys time.

We still like you. We'll sign a term sheet right now.

Jessica:
[\(00:41:49\)](#)

Amazing. That's really nice.

Jared:
[\(00:41:51\)](#)

Really saved the company. Yeah.

Carolynn:
[\(00:41:53\)](#)

Who was on the board of the I mean, I remember Bill and I remember Jeff being on the board. Yep. Who else was on the board?

Jared:
[\(00:41:58\)](#)

It was Bill and Jeff and me

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Jessica: And Trip.
[\(00:41:59\)](#)

Carolynn: Okay. Okay.
[\(00:42:00\)](#)

Jessica: And you weren't as observer?
[\(00:42:01\)](#)

Carolynn: I was an observer. Yeah. I just took the minutes. You know? That's what lawyers do it.
[\(00:42:03\)](#)

In meetings, you just make these vacuous minutes. So

Jessica: Then what?
[\(00:42:13\)](#)

Jared: So then we kept trying to grow Scribd. And, you know, Scribd is a I would argue that Scribd has never really had product market fit, not the way something like Airbnb does. You know? But who guys know, Paul saying it's better to make a product that, like, a few people love than a lot of people like. Yeah.

Like, Scribd is a classic example of why that is so true, which is they built a product that a lot of people like a Yeah. So we had millions of people coming to the site, but nobody really cared.

Carolynn: Yeah.
[\(00:42:47\)](#)

Jared: And we tried for years to, like, make a product that people, like, really loved and just, like, a website that host documents just, like, wasn't it. And so we had all this traffic, but, like, we never, like, ended up on this sort of, like, you know, like, escape velocity trajectory, like a like an Airbnb or a or a Stripe. There was one pretty pivotal moment about ten almost ten years in when we launched a second product, which is really inspired heavily by Emmett here at Twitch. So, you know, the justin.tv founders, we were like sister companies with them because we were doing YouTube for documents. Yep.

And they were doing YouTube for live video. That was, like, the one sentence of JTV. So we were both doing YouTube for Xs. We'd done YC at basically the same time. We lived in the same apartment building.

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I mean, we were so similar. And so we spent a lot of time with the Justin dot TV people, and we were very inspired by them. And they'd ended up winning a similar situation before they pivoted to Twitch where, like, they built a site that had a lot of traffic, but, like, nobody really cared. Yeah. A lot of it was pirated content.

It wasn't on a, like, escape velocity trajectory. And then Emma did pulled off the stunning pivot to Twitch, and we were very inspired by that. And so we're like, how do we do that?

Jessica:
[\(00:44:07\)](#)

Jared:
[\(00:44:09\)](#) And so our best idea was to pivot from being YouTube for documents to being Netflix for books. Oh. And this was when we launched, the unlimited book subscription service.

Carolynn:
[\(00:44:21\)](#) Yeah. Okay. Interesting. And this was ten years in.

Jared:
[\(00:44:25\)](#) Eight years in.

Carolynn:
[\(00:44:25\)](#) Eight years in.

Jessica:
[\(00:44:26\)](#) Which is pretty long.

Jared:
[\(00:44:27\)](#) It's pretty late to do, like, a big pivot.

Carolynn:
[\(00:44:29\)](#) Still really do you were slogging away at this for that long.

Jared:
[\(00:44:33\)](#) For that long.

Carolynn:
[\(00:44:33\)](#) Yeah. And you're still there. Like

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Jared: Yes. Scribd is still the it's the oldest independent YC company.
[\(00:44:36\)](#)

Carolynn: Yeah. I guess I meant to ask that a different way, which is, like, he eventually dropped off, but Tripp continued to do it to this day.
[\(00:44:41\)](#)

Jared: He left two years ago, but he did it for another eight like, seven or eight years after I left.
[\(00:44:47\)](#)

Carolynn: Yeah. Okay.
[\(00:44:52\)](#)

Jessica: Yeah. Think Tripp started a new company. Yeah. Yeah. Okay.
[\(00:44:53\)](#)

So when did you leave and why?

Jared: I left in 2015, and I left for a few reasons. It'd been I've I've I've been working on it for ten years. I never slotted that well into the CTO role. You know, Trip is the CEO. I was the CTO, but I wasn't, you know, I wasn't really CTO.

I was just a college student. Right? And so, like, even though, I guess, my title was CTO, I kinda just, like, did a bit of everything, and I like doing that. And I wasn't really the right person to be, like, a VP of engineering and just, like, run the engineering team and just, like, do engineering management at

Jessica: Just gonna say you didn't love doing being manager.
[\(00:45:36\)](#)

Jared: I didn't love being a manager, especially just an engineering manager. I really like being a founder and, like Yeah. Creating stuff.
[\(00:45:38\)](#)

Jessica: Yeah.
[\(00:45:45\)](#)

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Jared:
[\(00:45:46\)](#) And, you know, when I left here, was, you know, a couple 100 people. And by that scale, like, it really needed people who would be managers and, like, own functions and divisions and responsibilities. I actually think a core reason that we left is that Paul hadn't published the SA Founder Mode yet. Like, I actually think if Paul had published the essay Founder Mode, like, fifteen years earlier, Scribd would have ended up on a totally different trajectory. Because we had let RVCs do exactly what Paul said in his essay, which is, like, pressure us into, like, running the company in manager mode.

And so we had all these managers.

Jessica:
[\(00:46:21\)](#)

Jared:
[\(00:46:21\)](#) And, basically, I had to, like, operate within these very narrow lines or all the managers would get upset that I wasn't, like, playing by the rules of the system that they had created. And I just felt very stifled, and I felt like I was less good at this job of being, like, a manager of this, like, department than, like, a professional manager that I could hire who'd, like, worked at, you know, Google for ten years and had lots of, like, management experience. And I was just like, well, I guess this is what a big company is like. It must suck. And so, like, I don't wanna do this big company shit anymore.

I wanna go back and start another company and do the early stage startup stuff and be a founder because that's what I'm good at. That's what I understand. I feel like the like, and it's more fun.

Carolynn:
[\(00:47:05\)](#) Yeah. Yeah. At its biggest, how many employees did Scribd have?

Jared:
[\(00:47:09\)](#) 500.

Carolynn:
[\(00:47:10\)](#) Oh, no way. Yeah.

Jessica:
[\(00:47:11\)](#) That's big.

Carolynn:
[\(00:47:12\)](#) I don't remember that at all. 500. Wow. Not all in San Francisco, all in person?

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Jared: Not all in San Francisco, but mostly in San Francisco. Wow.
[\(00:47:17\)](#)

Jessica: So you leave after, you know, a long tenure at Scribd. Yeah. What are you off to do next?
[\(00:47:22\)](#)

Jared: I wanna start another startup. So I went back to, you know, my Y Combinator days and started, like, thinking of stuff to build and talking to potential cofounders. And, I had a few ideas that I was chasing, and I wanted some advice on which one to work on. And so I reached out to Sam Altman, who was the president of Y Combinator at the time, who I knew not that well, but casually from, like, the OGYC days because we'd done YC around the same time.
[\(00:47:29\)](#)

Jessica: Yeah.
[\(00:47:59\)](#)

Jared: And I asked him if I could do office hours with him to get advice on my new startup. And to his credit, he said, sure. And I went over to the tiny little Y Combinator office in San Francisco where he was working out of. I don't know if you Great. Great.
[\(00:47:59\)](#)

Remember this one. Kearny Street. Yeah. Know. Office.

Yep. I had, like, one room.

Carolynn: Yeah. No privacy.
[\(00:48:18\)](#)

Jared: No privacy. Yeah. And I met with Sam. And, I think I just had very good timing because unbeknownst to me, shortly before I scheduled this meeting with Sam, Garry Tan had left Y Combinator to start Initialized. And Sam had to run the winter twenty sixteen batch, and he was short a partner.
[\(00:48:20\)](#)

Oh. I think I just happened to show up at the right time where he was like, well We'll

Carolynn: Do this for a little bit of few months, Jared.
[\(00:48:48\)](#)

Jared: That was that was exactly his pitch to me. It was like, just do one batch, and then, like, you can go do your startup afterwards. And, I mean, it sounded awesome to me. I mean, I'd loved YC, you know, from the beginning. It had been super influential, and, like, I really respected Sam and the other partners at the time.
[\(00:48:50\)](#)

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And it just sound like it would be super fun to, like, hang out at YC for a batch and learn from everybody and work at some startups. And so that was my plan was to do one batch at YC and then go start my startup.

Carolynn: They always start with just one I love it.
[\(00:49:16\)](#)

Jessica: Now gateway drug. Ten years later.
[\(00:49:18\)](#)

Jared: Yes. Ten years later.
[\(00:49:20\)](#)

Carolynn: This is sorry. This is a little bit of a non sequitur. But to go back really quick, why do I remember David Sachs being on your board? Is that true or my

Jared: He was on my board for a while. He joined as an independent.
[\(00:49:30\)](#)

Carolynn: He was the independent.
[\(00:49:33\)](#)

Jessica: Why? Why him?
[\(00:49:34\)](#)

Jared: I mean, he like, he was a big deal. You know? He
[\(00:49:36\)](#)

Carolynn: Wasn't he a big deal back then?
[\(00:49:38\)](#)

Jared: He was a big deal back
[\(00:49:39\)](#)

Jessica: Yammer? Yammer.
[\(00:49:40\)](#)

Jared: Yeah. He sold he joined when he was still running Yammer, and then he sold Yammer for, like, a lot of money. It was about a billion dollars. Okay. And so he was, like, like, a pretty high profile person.

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Carolynn: Yeah. And you guys thought he would help you just get to the next level with his
[\(00:49:52\)](#)

Jared: Advice? We did or maybe just RVCs did it. Yeah. Think I think RVCs were like, you need
[\(00:49:57\)](#) RVCs were always pushing us to have more adult supervision. Like, from day one, that was the VC plea playbook in Silicon Valley time.

Mean, was the exact opposite of Founder Mode. It was like, oh, you guys are kids who are racing around on go karts. We need some adult supervision, here, we're gonna lose all our money.

Jessica: Yeah. Yeah. Yeah. Yeah. Yeah.
[\(00:50:16\)](#)

Interesting. Okay. So it's 2015. Who's at YC? What other partners are there that you're working with that?

Was it in the summer? Or

Jared: So my first batch was winter sixteen. Okay. It was Michael Seibel and Dalton Caldwell
[\(00:50:26\)](#) and Aaron Harris and Kevin Hale and Kassar Yunis and Justin Khan. And You. Tim Brady joined in the middle of the batch.

Jessica: Oh my gosh. What a memory you have, Jared. Yeah. Yeah. It's remarkable.
[\(00:50:41\)](#)

Carolynn: Dalton had just joined too, I'm pretty sure.
[\(00:50:47\)](#)

Jared: A couple years earlier.
[\(00:50:49\)](#)

Carolynn: No. I think it would I don't think it was a couple years. I think it was just one, like, one
[\(00:50:50\)](#) batch. Because I remember him coming to the Kearny office to sign

Jessica: His employment agreement. That's why I remember
[\(00:50:57\)](#)

Carolynn: That Dalton was not too far ahead of you.
[\(00:50:59\)](#)

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Jessica:
[\(00:51:02\)](#)

And you loved it?

Jared:
[\(00:51:03\)](#)

I loved it. I mean, it was just incredible. I mean, it was just yeah. I just, like, yeah, it was it was an incredible privilege to get to be one of the people that you had selected to be the, like, custodians of the incredible institution that you had started that had, like, launched all of our careers. I just felt like an opportunity I couldn't let go.

Jessica:
[\(00:51:25\)](#)

Who was in that batch? Do you remember?

Jared:
[\(00:51:27\)](#)

Some amazing companies were which were in winter sixteen. That was the batch where we had not one, not two, but \$3,000,000,000 hard tech companies in the same batch. Relativity Space, Astronius, and Boom Supersonic were all in that batch.

Jessica:
[\(00:51:41\)](#)

Oh my word.

Carolynn:
[\(00:51:42\)](#)

Yeah. Yeah.

Jared:
[\(00:51:43\)](#)

So there's a really good batch for hard tech.

Jessica:
[\(00:51:47\)](#)

Oh, because Sam was doing all the hard tech stuff then at that point. Yeah. Okay.

Jared:
[\(00:51:51\)](#)

But lots of other great stuff too.

Jessica:
[\(00:51:52\)](#)

You've been around for a long time at YC. What has YC retained in your opinion still that makes it so special?

Jared:
[\(00:52:04\)](#)

Well, one of the things that I've really enjoyed, especially the last two years, is I feel like the current iteration of YC, the Garry Tan era here in this building where we're in, is the most similar to the, you know, 2005, 2006 era that I did and that you guys all remember because AI has it's just like web2.o. It's literally just like web2.o. It's this new technology. Nobody knows what you can do with it. Nobody knows what kind of companies or the right kind of companies to start.

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Every month, they're inventing new stuff that you can do something with, and it's brought the same kind of founders back to YC that were there in 2006. You know? Recent college grads like me and me and Trip who just, like, think this stuff is really cool and wanna tinker with it.

Jessica: Yeah. And deeply technical.
[\(00:52:51\)](#)

Jared: And deeply technical.
[\(00:52:53\)](#)

Carolynn: Yeah. I would agree with that.
[\(00:52:54\)](#)

Jessica: Compared to other changes in human history, like, where do you think the AI revolution ranks?
[\(00:52:56\)](#)

Jared: I mean, this is gonna sound cliché, but I think it's probably gonna be the most important thing in all of human history.
[\(00:53:04\)](#)

Carolynn: Really? The most important?
[\(00:53:08\)](#)

Jared: Think so. Yeah. I mean, perhaps after the agricultural revolution, like, on par with that. Certainly much more important than the Internet.
[\(00:53:10\)](#)

Jessica: Yeah. Yeah. Wow.
[\(00:53:18\)](#)

Jared: Makes sense. Paul said the same thing.
[\(00:53:20\)](#)

Jessica: Oh, yeah. Paul, I think, has compared it to, like, the industrial revolution. Yeah.
[\(00:53:22\)](#)

Carolynn: Yeah. Well, I well, we can keep talking about AI, but I want to know did you wanna talk about YC software?
[\(00:53:27\)](#)

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Jessica: I did wanna talk about YC software because, you know, one of the unique things about Y Combinator, even dating back to the earliest days, is that we used, software more than other investment firms. And Jared has been a big part of the YC software team. Well, I mean, you started the first team. We didn't have a team before you. Yeah.

[\(00:53:35\)](#)

Tell us about how software plays a role.

Jared: Sure. This has been one of the most fun parts of my job at YC and one of the reasons that I didn't end up leaving YC to start a startup, actually. Was actually, like, core to this. So let me tell you about my first day on the job at Y Combinator. So I, you know, Sam recruits me.

[\(00:54:01\)](#)

He convinced me convinced me to join. He tells me to start on, like, Tuesday. I show up on Tuesday at the Kearny Street office, and here's what happens on the on the very first day. Do you guys remember Brett Gibson?

Jessica: Yes. Yes.

[\(00:54:31\)](#)

Jared: So Brett Gibson was this software engineer who worked at YC. Was the one software engineer who was working at YC at the time.

[\(00:54:32\)](#)

Jessica: He had been a YC founder with a company called Slinkset.

[\(00:54:39\)](#)

Jared: I forgot about Slinkset. Yes.

[\(00:54:43\)](#)

Carolynn: Okay.

[\(00:54:45\)](#)

Jessica: Didn't take off. But yeah.

[\(00:54:46\)](#)

Jared: And, my first day at Y Combinator was his last day at Y Combinator because he was leaving to join Tan at Initialize because Garry left to go to Initialize, brought Brett with him. Brett is now the president of Initialize. He now runs the firm. But at the time, he was the software engineer at YC. Yeah.

[\(00:54:48\)](#)

The only person who understood all the code that he'd written.

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Jessica: And by the way, he had also founded Post Haven with Garry. Oh, okay. That's what, like, my blog's on. Yeah. Yeah.
[\(00:55:09\)](#)

Yeah. Okay. Is on Post Haven.

Jared: Who means that thing now?
[\(00:55:20\)](#)

Jessica: I don't know. Paul and I were promised that if we put our stuff on Post Haven, it would last forever. That was sort of the promise from Garry, and it's still there. So I don't know who looks after it.
[\(00:55:21\)](#)

Jared: The promise.
[\(00:55:33\)](#)

Jessica: I'll have to ask Garry. Okay. So it was Brett's last day.
[\(00:55:34\)](#)

Jared: And so it was my first day, and I had, you know, I'd been the CTO at Scribd, so I was technical. I knew how to build web applications. And, like, Brett, basically, like, the hair on fire problem at YC was, like, the only engineer was leaving, and there was nobody who could, like, keep the website up and running. And I didn't have any other I didn't have anything else to do, so I was like, well, I can do that. And so I spent the day doing, like, a code handoff from Brett as he, like, taught me how everything worked.
[\(00:55:37\)](#)

And so day one, like, my job was to be the software engineer at YC.

Jessica: Wow. So Jared is not only YC partner, but also, the YC software team.
[\(00:56:10\)](#)

Carolynn: Engineer. An entire team. Team.
[\(00:56:17\)](#)

Jared: But I loved it. I thought the software was super fascinating. I mean, I'd, you know, I'd been a user of Hacker News from, like, the day that it launched. I'd been a user of Bookface from the day that Garry launched that. So I had followed this evolution of the software, and I found it a very intellectually interesting piece of software to write.
[\(00:56:21\)](#)

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I mean, it's like software for founders. It's software for a community that I cared about. One thing that I've learned is that, like, at the end of the day, I didn't really care that much about the Scribd users. Like, I cared that there were a lot of them and that they paid us lots of money, but I didn't really care that much about them as humans and that they had I didn't have much more of a personal relationship with them. There were, like, millions of them, and they were all over the world Yeah.

Versus, like, the YC software. Like, the users, like, the most important users of YC software all work in this building. And I know them all personally. And when we make something good, they tell us. And when we make something bad, they tell us.

And Yeah. It feels totally different from building, a mass consumer product.

Jessica: How much feedback did Paul give you on the software?
[\(00:57:14\)](#)

Jared: Well, he gave me some feedback last night. He recorded a bug that I need to fix after this.
[\(00:57:19\)](#)

Jessica: Ten years later, what's still harassing you.
[\(00:57:24\)](#)

Carolynn: He found a bug in, what, in book Facebook?
[\(00:57:27\)](#)

Jared: In internal. Yeah. Oh, no.
[\(00:57:29\)](#)

Jessica: Oh, Jared. Pay you you're getting some award for patience.
[\(00:57:31\)](#)

Jared: But it's been a great privilege to get to continue the tradition of building software at YC, which is something that Paul's doing. I mean, I mean, people who are listening might not know that, like, the whole time that Paul was running Y Combinator and doing interviews and office hours and batches and everything, he was building Hacker News. I still have no idea how he did it. Would he just, come home after a day of office hours and then, like, write code until midnight or something?

Jessica: He worked on it a lot. I remember that. But back when he was building it, YC wasn't quite as busy because there were fewer founders.
[\(00:57:58\)](#)

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Carolynn: Yeah.
[\(00:58:06\)](#)

Jessica: So you always have to keep that in mind. But it was always an important part of what we did. And I remember Paul built, like, me, incorporation documents that he put that all online so you could just fill in the blanks, it would propagate.

Carolynn: Yeah.
[\(00:58:23\)](#)

Jessica: You know?
[\(00:58:23\)](#)

Carolynn: Yeah.
[\(00:58:23\)](#)

Jared: And so I feel like, you know, from the very beginning, there's been this tradition of, like, YC, unlike other venture firms that just, like, throw people at problems, we, like, write software to scale because that's what Paul knew how to do. And, we've, like, kept that tradition going. And Carolynn is now super involved in, like, the nth level descendant of the software that Paul wrote for you for legal documents. We now have a three person team that, like, automates stuff for the legal team.

Carolynn: So by the way, so I'll just stop for a minute and give Jared huge prod Jared and all the other people who work on this at YC. Building software for lawyers is boring, and it is unsexy, but it is so, so helpful.

Jared: It's so important.
[\(00:59:06\)](#)

Carolynn: It's so great that this is built, and it really helps our team a lot.
[\(00:59:07\)](#)

Jessica: What about software in the application process? Can you talk at all about that?
[\(00:59:11\)](#)

Jared: Sure. Well, that was one of the first pieces of software that Paul wrote. Right? It was, like, software to manage the applications. Because the first batch, you printed them out.

Carolynn: Oh, yeah.
[\(00:59:24\)](#)

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Jared:
[\(00:59:24\)](#) You passed them around the desk. Yep. But at what point did you stop printing them out and started reading them on computers?

Jessica:
[\(00:59:29\)](#) It was pretty early because I think that was such a huge pain point. And, you know, my cofounders were three software engineers. They were like, there's gotta be a better way than printing out PDFs and writing all the scores on it. How I remember that changed my life, though, when they moved the applications to software. What I used to do, my I wouldn't read all the applications.

I would go through as they filtered to the top, and we knew there's a chance we're gonna interview them. I'd go through and hand, mark any red flags I'd see. Yeah. Like, is someone not quitting their job? Is there an unequal hugely unequal equity split?

Any red flag, I'd go through and manually designate that. And that's really laborious. Now that's all automate automated. And this is not, by the way, oh, we're not gonna fund them. Just a red flag.

Carolynn:
[\(01:00:25\)](#) Yeah. Mhmm. Do need to ask about?

Jessica:
[\(01:00:26\)](#) Something to ask about. So I remember having all of that all of the applications online was huge. And we could track who applied for a second time. And, I mean, how sophisticated is it now?

Jared:
[\(01:00:39\)](#) It's pretty darn sophisticated. We've we've been we've we've been making this better every batch for 24 batches, so it's gone pretty good now.

Jessica:
[\(01:00:47\)](#) Yeah. We used to always joke the initial software used to, like, weed out the goat farmers, you know, who we weren't gonna find. I think goat farmers. I don't know. Because we really did have someone apply that was a goat farmer.

Well Yeah.

Carolynn:
[\(01:01:00\)](#) I'm not surprised at all by that.

Jessica:
[\(01:01:02\)](#) And we used to have alumni, Carolynn, do early stage passes and sort of basically weed out definite no's. Yeah. Yeah. So that's been automated.

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Jared:
[\(01:01:13\)](#) There's a cool part about Software at YC that I think people outside don't know anything about, which is that the fact that we build our own software keeps the partners current and technical. I remember Paul told me this offhand a few years ago. He was like, when he was running Hacker News, it gave him a lot of empathy for the founders because he was dealing with the same stuff that they were. He was dealing with, like, bugs, and the server goes down, and the database is full, and all of these, like, problems that when that happen when you run a website. And so I think a lot of founders see the partners as just these, I don't know, like, manager people who, like, just, do office hours and stuff.

But, like, the partners now are heavily involved in the software. It's not just me. Actually, all the partners are, like, involved in building the software at YC, and we've now we have so much software that, like, we've divided it up into, like, five different products, and each GP is, like, involved with one or two of the products. And it's been really cool in the AI era, especially. The majority of the software team at YC now is actually focused on basically building AI stuff into the YC software.

And because of that, we get to be the early adopters of all of the stuff that our companies are building and all the technologies that they are working with, and we get to basically sort of be, like, founders of AI companies and build really complicated prompts and AI agents just like all of our founders are doing. And that's been incredibly helpful, actually, for us as partners because, like, the stuff that we're investing in is the same stuff that we're, like, using and building all day, and it it's made us much smarter about AI.

Jessica:
[\(01:02:57\)](#) Yeah. Wow. Do you think you need to be super technical to be an a good investor in this new world of AI?

Jared:
[\(01:03:05\)](#) I don't think you need to be. I think it's helpful. I think also the definition of technical is going to change. You know? Like, now a lot of the code that we write, like, is English.

And lawyers actually are amazing at writing prompts because the lawyers are the original prompt engineers.

Carolynn:
[\(01:03:24\)](#) I actually would I yeah. I agree with that.

Jared:
[\(01:03:26\)](#) You guys have been programming in English for, like, hundreds of years. Yeah. The rest of the world has finally caught on that you can program in English.

Jessica:
[\(01:03:32\)](#) Carolynn, I wanna see some results here.

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Carolynn: [\(01:03:34\)](#) I wanna see you create something. Want to show you what we work with because you'd be amazed. It's so good.

Jared: [\(01:03:41\)](#) Yeah. Have you seen the new stuff? No. We should show you the new stuff. It's actually really cool.

Carolynn: [\(01:03:45\)](#) I mentioned to her that I really wanted to show her, like, the pipelines and stuff because

Jessica: [\(01:03:48\)](#) In the legal department. Yeah. I'll stop by. You know I'm secretly a legal nerd, and I love the stuff. I used to do a lot of it.

Carolynn: [\(01:03:55\)](#) Yes. I know. I know. You don't have to be a secret legal nerd. You can be an out legal nerd.

Jessica: [\(01:04:00\)](#) I would be an out legal nerd. Let me see what other questions I have. When you were talking about the past two years have been really exciting, and it feels like sort of the early days of YC and that those types of people. Do you think it's fair to say that there are fewer sort of fakers or, you know, posers, if you will, who are doing YC or doing a startup for just the coolness factor or the brand, and they're actually more genuinely technical people who like to create things?

Jared: [\(01:04:32\)](#) I certainly hope so. You know, I think there's probably two forces happening simultaneously. I think the first force is that, the technology is really interesting, and so it's pulled a lot of people into startups who were maybe not, like, money driven. They're just, like, actually genuinely really interested in the technology, which I think was not really true in 2021. Like, there just hadn't been any new technology in a long time.

And so the people doing startups back then were mostly people who wanted to build a business, which is a totally reasonable reason to do a startup, of course. But, like, there weren't that many people who were just, like, deeply, like, technology focused. And so it's brought in those people. But I think there's a second, like, cultural trend, which is, like, Y Combinator worked. Like, when you guys started it, you wanted there to be more startups.

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You wanted being a founder to be normalized, to be something that, like, was way more common than it was back then, something that, like, didn't seem so weird, and you succeeded. And now, it's, like, far more mainstream than it was before. And so you have a lot more people who are doing a startup for the same reasons that you would get an internship at OpenAI right now because it, like, looks good on your resume, and it's what the cool people are doing and their status and prestige associated with it.

Jessica: I wanna talk about Light Cone, your fabulous podcast. How long have you been doing this?
[\(01:05:54\)](#)

Jared: A year and a half now.
[\(01:06:00\)](#)

Carolynn: Oh my god. Has it been that long?
[\(01:06:01\)](#)

Jessica: Yeah. How often do you launch episodes?
[\(01:06:03\)](#)

Jared: We're supposed to do it every two weeks, but realistically, it's been more like once a month.
[\(01:06:06\)](#)

Jessica: Okay. If Garry had his way, you'd be doing it every week.
[\(01:06:10\)](#)

Carolynn: Garry is a content creator.
[\(01:06:15\)](#)

Jessica: But it's I was on the show and loved it, and I think you talk about such interesting things on every episode. What's been your favorite one of your favorite episodes?
[\(01:06:18\)](#)

Jared: Well, other than the one we did with you, of course.
[\(01:06:30\)](#)

Jessica: Stop it.
[\(01:06:32\)](#)

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Jared:
[\(01:06:34\)](#) I think my favorite episode was the one that we did on, how AI agents are gonna become the new vertical SaaS companies because I think we kinda called the trend when some people were talking about it, but it wasn't, like, quite obvious yet in the world. And I think it's played out the way that that we said that it was going predicted. Going to. And I've talked to a lot of founders who told me that, like, that episode was a big part of their inspiration to, like, work on their current idea that they, like, heard that episode, and they were like, oh, I should start an AI agent company. That makes sense.

And then they did.

Jessica:
[\(01:07:01\)](#)

Carolynn:
[\(01:07:02\)](#) Wow. That's very cool. How long ago was that one?

Jared:
[\(01:07:04\)](#) That was about a year ago.

Carolynn:
[\(01:07:05\)](#) Oh, about a year. Okay. Okay.

Jessica:
[\(01:07:06\)](#) And do you guys sometimes have guests, but not always.

Carolynn:
[\(01:07:09\)](#) Yeah. What did you guys talk about when you were on?

Jessica:
[\(01:07:13\)](#) Oh, we talked a lot about early days of YC and stuff. Because I can't talk about how AI agents are gonna be the vertical integration of SaaS. I'm not even sure if I just said that correctly. That was funny. It was a lot of fun, though.

It was a lot of fun because, you know, you got Garry, Harge, Diana, Jared. It's a fun group.

Carolynn:
[\(01:07:36\)](#) Yeah. For sure.

Jessica:
[\(01:07:37\)](#) Jared, we had so much fun catching up with you. I cannot believe all the, like, fascinating nuggets you've thrown out that I either don't remember or didn't know.

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Jared: I had such a great time, gassy.
[\(01:07:49\)](#)

Carolynn: Also, You must be really organized about your emails. Did you pull those up out of the archives, or did you just do a search?
[\(01:07:51\)](#)

Jared: I just searched. Okay.
[\(01:07:56\)](#)

Carolynn: Alright.
[\(01:07:57\)](#)

Jared: Well, thanks to Gmail, I have all the old emails. Yeah. Gave us unlimited stars. I got all the old emails.
[\(01:07:58\)](#)

Jessica: That's so
[\(01:08:03\)](#)

Jared: Good. I love I love rereading the, like, the old emails from, like because, know, I've been getting Y Combinator emails since, like, 2006. And so, like, the, like, the whole, like, archaeological record is there.
[\(01:08:03\)](#)

Jessica: Well, that's what I'm banking on for my book that I someday I keep threatening to write.
[\(01:08:15\)](#)

Jared: The only way history of Y Combinator?
[\(01:08:20\)](#)

Jessica: Yes. Oh, please do. That would be amazing. Well, I'll be coming to you because you clearly remember them, but I swear the only thing I can rely on is are my email archives. Yes.
[\(01:08:22\)](#)

But we loved having you. It was so much fun. I hope you're at Y Combinator for another ten years.

Jared: Okay. Good morning.
[\(01:08:38\)](#)

Jessica: We won't let you leave.
[\(01:08:38\)](#)

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Jared:
[\(01:08:40\)](#) Thank you guys so much. You were both so important in everything that's happened to me since I was 20 years old.

Jessica:
[\(01:08:44\)](#) So It was 20 years old. Wow.

Jared:
[\(01:08:47\)](#) Thank you so much for everything you guys have done for

Jessica:
[\(01:08:49\)](#) Aw. Thanks, Jared. Talk to you soon. Bye. Bye.

Oh, Carolyn, that was so much fun.

Carolynn:
[\(01:08:58\)](#) Well, Jared is a favorite, and he is such a nice person. And it is I actually had I had actually forgotten the whole Scribd story. Me too. Really? Glad that he walked us through that because I knew I knew kind of it generally.

I've obviously known him since he was 20, but I didn't remember all those details. So

Jessica:
[\(01:09:15\)](#) I didn't remember so many of the things that he said. So that was really fun to be reminded of all those things.

Carolynn:
[\(01:09:21\)](#) And he does have a great memory and the fact that he could just dig around and find all those emails. I mean, I I'm so glad everyone's saving those emails because they will be very helpful for you.

Jessica:
[\(01:09:29\)](#) I think that they will. And Jared is such a nice Yes. Person too.

Carolynn:
[\(01:09:35\)](#) He is. And he has

Jessica:
[\(01:09:36\)](#) And he's so smart. And he's so smart.

Carolynn:
[\(01:09:39\)](#) And he's got a great dog, and he's got a great wife, and he's like just He's awesome. He's awesome.

Jessica:
[\(01:09:44\)](#) I love doing it in person.

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Carolynn: Yeah. Actually, that
[\(01:09:46\)](#)

Jessica: Is really nice. I'm sorry I'm not here as much as I would like to be. But I loved catching up
[\(01:09:47\)](#) with him, and I think it's gonna be a great episode.

Carolynn: Yeah. For sure.
[\(01:09:55\)](#)

Jessica: Alright. I'll talk to you later. Okay. Bye. Bye.
[\(01:09:56\)](#)